The Passage of Doom



An Underdark side trek for 4th-7th level characters

by Tony Petrecca

Cover Art by Gary Dupuis

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A Sneak Peek Excerpt from Journey Through the Center of the Underdark 2

A 1-hour Underdark side trek for 4th-7th level characters

by Tony Petrecca

Play tested by Shawn Brock, Gary Edwards, Brigitte Kephart, Chris Osborne, Rod Schroeder and Dennis Wilson



Cover art by Gary Dupuis
http://www.gdupuis.com

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While traversing tunnels on the Darklake the party encounters threats by land, sea, and air.

Your Darklake voyage takes you into a narrow, thirty-foot wide, Faerzeress lit tunnel of eerie quiet. The sound of the paddles gently lapping on the water echoes on the walls, while water occasionally drips from unseen sources high above. The eerie purple glow illuminates blind cave fish that move mindlessly about near the surface of the water. Some of the fish are so unaware of your presence that they run into your boat.

As you round a bend you see a diamond shaped small islet of limestone and stalagmites fifty feet ahead. The tunnel forks at the islet, with the Darklake flowing to the left or right of the forty foot wide bit of dry rock.

Your eyes are drawn to a wicked sight upon the islet – a pyramid of bones, at least eight feet high and five feet wide at its base. Sitting atop this pile is a large horned ram's skull, carefully positioned to be facing your direction, its empty sockets gazing intently at you. As you consider the significance of this display - ZZZZAP!

Some bizarre, violent beam of light from behind a stalactite above the islet just put a hole in your keel boat! You're taking on water, fast, but you don't have time to think. A ten foot diameter floating sphere has emerged from behind the large stalactite and is floating your way.

Roll for initiative!

This Faerzeress infused area is heavily tainted by the influence of Orcus. As a result any creature that dies in the area and is not laid to rest properly is raised as a zombie or skeleton within 1 hour. Furthermore, undead in the area have advantage vs being turned.

The Zombie Beholder

The Orcus tainted Faerzeress has attracted a **Zombie Beholder,** and the taint has enhanced the beast somewhat. It is not entirely mindless anymore - it has an intelligence score of 8 (-1), rather than 3. Additionally it can use two rays per round, with one always being its disintegration ray that it enjoys aiming at boats.

Only a few days ago the **Zombie Beholder** was drawn to the taint of negative energy in the area and moved in, disintegrating a home for itself in the large stalactite above the islet. It now serves the taint, seeking victims to slay and increasing the numbers of undead in the area. Its preferred method of slaughter is drowning and it uses its disintegration ray to sink the boats of travelers who come near. This tunnel is well traveled so it has already found several victims. As a result the beast is not alone.

Zombies in the water

The Darklake is about twenty-feet deep in these passages. Shuffling about at the bottom of the Darklake in this area are two boat loads of victims. Two keel boats of Duegar and Derro fell victim to the beholder recently, and as a result eight Duergar **zombies** and five Derro **zombies** (Use standard **zombie** stats) wander the bottom of the Darklake here. They shuffle mindlessly about, gnawing at cave fish, waiting for other boats to sink. Should any character sink to the bottom they will be attacked by 1d3 per round until all thirteen **zombies** swarm them.

Disintegration, Sinking, Swimming and Underwater Combat.

Keel Boats (pg 119 DMG) have 100 hit points. The Zombie Beholder's disintegration ray averages 45 hit points of damage. Large or smaller inanimate objects are instantly disintegrated per the rules, which puts the PC's in the water on the first shot.

However, rather than instant destruction I suggest the first ray puts a hole in the boat, giving it 10 rounds to sink. On the second hit the boat starts breaking up, accelerating its sinking by 5 rounds. On a third hit the boat is destroyed. This provides some sinking boat suspense and gives the player's a chance to attempt to scramble to repair the boat, plugging the holes through physical means or a *mending* spell. How well those efforts work is up to the DM.

Swimming (PHB 182) is considered difficult terrain unless a creature has a swim speed.

Use Suffocation rules for drowning-

Suffocating (PHB 183) *A creature can hold its breath for a*

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number of minutes equal to 2+ it's Constitution modifier. When a creature runs out of breath, it can survive a number of rounds equal to its Constitution modifier (minimum 1 round). At the start of its next turn, it drops to 0 hit points and is dying.

Underwater Combat (PHB 198) *When making a **melee weapon attack,** a creature that doesn't have a swimming speed has disadvantage on the attack roll unless the weapon is a dagger, javelin, shortsword, spear or trident.*

*A **ranged weapon attack** automatically misses a target beyond the weapon's normal range. Even against a target within normal range, the attack roll has disadvantage unless the weapon is a crossbow, a net, or a thrown weapon like a javelin (including a spear, trident, or dart).*

Creatures and objects that are fully immersed in water have resistance to fire damage.

The Islet and the Shrine

The islet is roughly diamond shaped, forty feet wide and sixty feet deep. In its center is a large stalagmite, 25 feet in diameter, that reaches up 80 feet. High above that stalagmite is a huge 60-foot thick stalactite. The **Zombie Beholder** has carved a rough cavern lair for itself in this stalactite.

The pyramid of bones is a bizarrely spontaneous creation, a shrine to Orcus that gathered itself together out of nothingness. The rams head skull that sits atop it does not belong to any underdark species.

Should any intelligent living creature set foot on the islet the bones burst forth and attack. They immediately form ten **skeletons** and one rams headed **Minotaur Skeleton.** If **zombies** remain in the water they will be attracted to the fight on land as well. 1D3 will emerge per round from various directions until all thirteen are engaged.

Treasure

The Duergar had some valuables in their boat. At the bottom of the water twenty feet off the islet to the right can be found a small chest containing 120 silver, 30 gold, four spell scrolls (three wizard- P*oison Spray, Burning Hands*, *Mirror Image* and one cleric – *inflict wounds*) and one *Driftglobe.*

If boats were lost then a functional keel boat, or two, may have conveniently washed ashore on the back side of the island, their owners no doubt having fallen victim to some peril.

Finally -If your player's had to lose armor to avoid drowning you could provide them with replacement suits on the islet, of lesser, equal, or greater utility, as you see fit.

Should the PCs manage to enter the **Beholder's** carved lair in the huge stalactite high above, it is nothing but a big disintegration carved hole.

Changing Difficulty

For a lower level party reduce the number of **zombies** and **skeletons** and eliminate the **Zombie Beholder's** enhancements.

For a higher level party change the drowned victims to **ghouls** or **ghasts,** give the Beholder use of more eye rays, and perhaps add another **Zombie Beholder!**

The difficulty of the encounter can also be adjusted by having the party attacked closer or farther from shore, and by adjusting the effectiveness of disintegration to instant destruction. Nothing ramps up peril quite like an entire party swimming through undead infested waters.

I hope you enjoyed this early draft sample from the upcoming *Journey Through the Center of the Underdark Part 2*. I hope to have the full product out soon.

Until then, please take a look at my other DmsGuild offerings -

Journey Through the Center of the Underdark

A compilation of encounters for your *Rage of Demons Out of the Abyss* campaign.

and

Dragons! Volume 1 - Chromatic Dragons

Six new age categories for all five Chromatic Dragon types - Very Young, Juvenile, Young Adult, Wyrm and Great Wyrm.

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